



Turning Point

Marrying V.K. Thankappan, a CPI(M) activist, who was instrumental in bringing her to the field of political activism from social service.

The diminutive Susan Thankappan, 40, does not look the powerhouse she is. This member of the Edathala Gram Panchayat in Ernakulam district has now assumed an iconic status as the protector of vanishing paddy fields. It was no easy task as she came to know on April 23 last year when miscreants deployed by land sharks assaulted Susan and her rubber-tapper husband V.K. Thankappan for opposing conversion of paddy fields. But the incident only made her more determined. Today, if her Ward No. 4 stands alone in the panchayat for not having lost an inch of paddy field in the past three years to shopping malls and apartment complexes, all credit goes to her.

An Anganwadi teacher, Susan was a political novice when she was fielded by the CPI(M) for the panchayat elections in 2005. What made her the party choice was her struggle to make her Anganwadi the best in the locality. "I used to stage dharnas to get what was due to the Anganwadi's children," says the woman who rocked her conservative village when she, a Christian, married a Hindu. After getting elected, putting a stop to the vanishing paddy fields in her ward—where land prices were rising at a rapid pace owing to the Cochin International Airport nearby—was her priority. She saw to it that the panchayat denied permission to all requests to convert the fields in her ward. When the land sharks went ahead even without permission, she stood in front of the huge JCBS. It was a lonely fight but Susan's moral strength was unchallengeable. Today, she has a small band of young supporters. "Even some of those who came to attack us are with us," Susan says. She recently succeeded in closing down a 20-year-old polluting unit. Give Susan a cause, and she will make it a magnificent obsession.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

MR NANDAKUMAR



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The plight of flood victims in and around Gorakhpur changed his perception. That is when he decided to work for farmers' welfare.

He is different, determined and loves to coin phrases to convey his feelings. Utkarsh Sinha is a one-man army, fighting for the right to food and his favourite slogan is "I am not a lab rat". A wanderer by nature, he is sometimes found in the interiors of drought-affected Bundelkhand, asking people to harvest water and organising women to create grain banks to help each other during famines. He can also be found attending a global conference on food security and livelihood in Mali.

Founder-director of the Centre for Contemporary Studies and Research, an advocacy and research organisation based in Lucknow, and national vice-president of Indian Social Action Forum, Sinha began his career as a journalist. While working with a newspaper, he

came into contact with an NGO, Sahyog, that was working in flood-prone areas. His task of documentation of an indigenous coping mechanism in a flood-prone area changed his life forever.

Protecting the rights of the marginalised, resisting globalisation and defending democracy are his core concerns. Sinha is the author of four books on social issues and a booklet by him was used as the foundation paper by the state's Agriculture Department to draft its first-ever agriculture policy. He was also part of the project implementation committee on women farmers and Bihar youth policy as well as the national agriculture policy. Though he occasionally gets associated with NGOs in the course of his field work, he says, "I have realised they can't bring any revolution. It is only the people who can do this."

by Farzand Ahmed